The highway restaurants offered delicious thepla, bun maska, dhoklas, sweet tea, and fresh orange jalebis. A few hours into the drive, trucks lugging oil, gas, and cargo drove past us, heading towards signs that announced directions to Jamnagar. Slowly, from built-up Ahmedabad, the landscape changed to drier lands with goats and goatherds and the sharp sun, which played laser tag on people's heads.

The trip was filled with the car's stubborn Bluetooth signal that refused to be trapped by my phone and a chatty driver named Jigar Bhai, who, in intervals, spoke to his network of driver-friends ferrying tourists around sites like Somnath and Dwarka. Occasionally, he sighed over the condition of his state's roads. "Rajasthan has better roads," he said, clicking his tongue.

Despite A.R. Rahman's best efforts at composing songs that kept us road-trippers upbeat for hours, weariness eventually set in. Only the bright lights of the White Rann Tent City in Dhordo Village woke me up later that evening. The Tent City, run by hospitality group Evoke Experiences, was filled with fluttering flags and visitors hopping in and out of shops that make up the evening *haat* or marketplace, running their fingers over local handlooms or trying out terracotta earrings.

Some visitors watched live demonstrations of block printing on textiles or an artisan fashioning jewellery out of clay. If I had wanted a massage to relieve my long hours in the car, I could have visited the spa, but I chose to sink into an armchair and relax by looking up at a star-filled sky.

For 100 days from November 11 to March 15, 400 tents come up close to the scenic 'White Rann'—or the white desert made of sand and salt—attracting visitors from across India and abroad. It was most popular with Gujaratis; at least 60 per cent of the guests were domestic tourists, but people from across the country have forced the tent city chefs to cater to all palates. From Gujarat's *sev tameta*, *ringan na oro*, *bhajra* rotis and jaggery which I enjoyed tasting; the menu also included cream of cauliflower soup, dosas, paneer lababdar and gajar halwa.

The brightly lit tent city, alphabetically divided into clusters, offers various accommodation options and electric buggies that move guests from dining areas to evenings filled with song and dance. Every evening, a host curates a cultural show offering performances from the Siddhi community native to Gujarat and Karnataka

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KUTCH PACKAGE (Clockwise from left) A musician at the cultural show in the White Rann Tent City in Dhordo village; an aerial view of the landscape around the tent city; Indus Valley civilisation motifs adorn the city; a tourist tries her hand at pottery; individual tents at the city